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At-Home Medical Tests

What are at-home medical tests?

At-home medical tests, also known as home use tests, are kits you can buy online or at your local pharmacy or supermarket. These kits allow you to test for, screen, or monitor certain diseases and conditions in the privacy of your own home. Common at-home tests can include:

- Pregnancy tests [<https://medlineplus.gov/lab-tests/pregnancy-test/>] .
- Blood glucose [<https://medlineplus.gov/bloodglucose.html>] (blood sugar) tests, which may be used regularly to help you manage your **diabetes** [<https://medlineplus.gov/diabetes.html>] .
- Fecal occult blood tests [<https://medlineplus.gov/lab-tests/fecal-occult-blood-test-fobt/>] , which screen for colon cancer [<https://medlineplus.gov/colorectalcancer.html>] .
- Tests that check for signs of infectious diseases [<https://medlineplus.gov/infectiousdiseases.html>] , such as hepatitis [<https://medlineplus.gov/hepatitis.html>] , HIV [<https://medlineplus.gov/hiv.html>] , and COVID-19 [<https://medlineplus.gov/covid19coronavirusdisease2019.html>] .
- Genetic tests [<https://medlineplus.gov/genetictesting.html>] , which may show if you are at higher risk for certain diseases.

There are two types of at-home tests:

- **Self-tests** involve taking a sample of a body fluid, such as blood [<https://medlineplus.gov/blood.html>] , urine, or saliva, and applying it to the kit as directed. These tests provide immediate results.
- **Self-collection tests** also allow you to take your sample at home, but then you'll need to package it and mail it to a lab. You can get the results from your health care provider, or you may be able to get them in an online portal with a unique login and password. How long it takes to get your results can vary, based on the type of test.

Many kits are available without a prescription, but you should still ask your provider for advice on which kits to use.

Other names: home use tests, home test kits

How are they used?

At-home testing is frequently used to:

- Find or screen for disorders, such as high cholesterol [<https://medlineplus.gov/cholesterol.html>] or certain infections, before you have any symptoms. This may allow you to get treatment earlier and avoid serious complications. It may also help prevent the spread of infectious diseases.
- Help diagnose pregnancy [<https://medlineplus.gov/pregnancy.html>] early so you can take steps to care for your health and your baby's by scheduling an appointment with your provider.
- Monitor chronic diseases, such as diabetes and high blood pressure [<https://medlineplus.gov/highbloodpressure.html>] . This may allow you to make more quickly begin making treatment and/or lifestyle changes to improve your condition.

How do I use an at-home test?

The specific instructions will vary, depending on the type and brand of the test kit. Below are examples of some common at-home tests and how they are performed.

Pregnancy Test

- Used to diagnose pregnancy by checking for a hormone called human chorionic gonadotropin (HCG). HCG is normally only produced during pregnancy.
- Test procedure:
 - If possible, plan to do the test in the morning. Most pregnancy tests recommend using your first morning urine for more accurate results.
 - You will hold a test strip in your urine stream or collect your urine in a cup and place the test strip into the cup.
 - If you are pregnant, the strip will display a colored line, a double line, or a symbol such as a plus sign. The type of display depends on the brand.

Follow up with your provider if the test is positive or if the test was negative but you still think you might be pregnant.

Glucose Test

- Used to monitor blood glucose (blood sugar) levels. This test is essential for some people with diabetes. If your blood glucose gets **too high** [<https://medlineplus.gov/hyperglycemia.html>] or **too low for you** [<https://medlineplus.gov/hypoglycemia.html>] , it can cause dangerous complications.
- Test procedure:
 - You will prick your finger with a device called a lancet to get a drop of blood.
 - You place the blood on a test strip and insert it into a monitor.
 - The meter will show your glucose level.

- There are different types of glucose meters, and they work in slightly different ways. Some may not even require you to prick your finger. Be sure to read and follow all the instructions carefully.

Fecal Occult Blood Test

- Used to check stool for signs of colon cancer. Your provider will give you a test kit.
- Test procedure:
 - You will collect small stool samples and place them on a special card or container.
 - Seal and mail the card or container to your provider or a lab.
 - The sample will be checked for blood. Blood in the stool can be a sign of colon cancer or other conditions.
 - The testing laboratory or your provider will contact you with the results.

Hepatitis C [<https://medlineplus.gov/hepatitisc.html>] Test

- Used to find out if you have hepatitis C now or were infected in the past.
- Test procedure:
 - You will prick your finger with a device called a lancet to get a drop of blood.
 - You place the blood sample on a special piece of paper.
 - You will seal and mail the paper to a laboratory.
 - The testing laboratory or your provider will contact you with the results.

Genetic Test

- Used to find out if you may be at higher risk of cancer or other diseases by looking for certain genetic changes. Genetic tests may also be used to find out information about your ancestors. These tests work by comparing your genetic data with genetic data from large groups of people.
- Test procedure:
 - You can order many of these tests yourself. Others require a provider's prescription.
 - Most test kits will instruct you to provide a saliva sample or to take a swab from the inside of your cheek.
 - You will mail the sample to the test company or as directed.
 - The testing company or your provider will contact you with the results.

If you are using a test to find out your risk of disease, be sure to talk to your provider. These tests can't diagnose diseases and are not as accurate as traditional lab-based genetic tests. But if a home test shows you may be at higher risk, your provider can monitor your health more closely.

COVID-19 Test

- Used to find out if you have COVID-19 [<https://medlineplus.gov/covid19testing.html>] . A viral test tells if you have a current infection. Viral tests can be either rapid tests [<https://medlineplus.gov/lab-tests/rapid-tests/>] , which you can do at home, or laboratory tests.
- Test procedure:
 - Buy a self-test online or at a store.
 - Most test kits will instruct you to take a nasal swab and swirl it inside your nostril.
 - You will place your sample swab in a vial and then place that in the test unit.
 - You will have results in 30 minutes or less displaying whether you have the COVID-19 virus. The type of display may depend on the brand of the test.
 - Follow the test kit instructions.

Is there anything else I need to know about at-home medical tests?

At-home medical tests can provide helpful information, but they are not a replacement for guidance and treatment by your provider. After at-home testing, you should follow up with your provider regardless of the result.

In addition, when purchasing and using an at-home test kit:

- **Only use FDA-approved or FDA-authorized tests.** The FDA has strict requirements for the quality and accuracy of home test kits.
- **Follow the test instructions exactly.** Even minor changes can affect your results.
- **Don't buy or use expired tests.** Chemicals in the test may lose their effectiveness over time.
- **Don't change your medicines** because of a test result without talking with your provider. Let your provider know about your results. They can tell you if you need to change your medicine or the dose you take based on your at-home test results.

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